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Placement Directors SangMok Lee (sangmoklee@wustl.edu) David Rivers (davidrivers@wustl.edu)

Education

2021–2027	Ph.D. in Economics, Washington University in St. Louis (expected May 2027) Dissertation: Essays on Venture Capital, Wealth, and Entrepreneurial Finance Committee: Yongseok Shin (Chair), Philipp Grübener, Rodolfo Manuelli
2019–2021	M.Phil. in Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
2018–2019	M.Sc. in Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
2012–2016	B.S.Sc. in Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

Fields

Research	Macroeconomics, Macro-Finance, Entrepreneurial Finance
Teaching	Macroeconomics, Econometrics, Computational Economics (Python)

References

Yongseok Shin (Chair)
Douglass C. North Distinguished Professor in Economics
Washington University in St. Louis
yshin@wustl.edu

Rodolfo Manuelli
James S. McDonnell Distinguished University Professor
Washington University in St. Louis
manuelli@wustl.edu

Philipp Grübener
Assistant Professor of Economics
Washington University in St. Louis
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Job Market Paper

More Investors, Not Bigger Deals: How Public Money Can Increase the Number of Venture Capital-Backed Startups When Founders Become Investors

To increase the number of venture capital-backed startups when successful founders become investors, should government spend on creating non-founder investor slots (non-founder-slot policy) or scaling capital per deal (bigger-deal policy)? In a calibrated search and bargaining model, founders seek investor slots as workers seek jobs; each slot can back one startup and is filled or vacant. Some founders exit successfully by selling or listing startups, pass the accredited-investor wealth test, and open vacancies. Mainly through this recycling loop, each added vacancy multiplies into 2.11 vacancies, counting itself. The model predicts that, at equal spending, the non-founder-slot policy raises founder welfare (certainty equivalent of searching) more than the bigger-deal policy. First, it directly adds vacancies, which multiply and strengthen founders' bargaining, unlike the bigger-deal policy's higher average exit value. Second, most startups fail, so risk aversion caps a representative founder's equity value at 11% of expected payoff. 5% more non-founder slots raise founder welfare by 2.90% (51% through recycling) and participation by 3.84%; equal bigger-deal spending raises them by 0.40% (46% through recycling) and 0.19%. Per dollar spent at these policy sizes, the non-founder-slot policy raises exit value by \$1.48, the bigger-deal policy by \$0.63. Restoring the wealth test's real value at its 1982 adoption would cut founder-investors by two-thirds and founder welfare by a third.

Work in Progress

Financing Innovation over the Business Cycle (with Leo Lam)
We ask whether start-ups first financed in hot venture markets innovate differently. Because SDC Platinum and Orbis share no firm identifier, we fuzzy-match the 50,000 US start-ups with a seed or early-stage venture deal in SDC Platinum to Orbis firm records on names, web domains, telephone numbers and addresses, linking 7,500 of them to their patents; the 32,668 firms first financed from 1980 to 2019 form the estimation sample.

Who Matches with Whom: Sorting and the Speed of Top Wealth Inequality
Which founders are paired with which venture funds sets how fat the top tail of wealth is. In the frictionless benchmark, more accurate pairing fattens the tail at once, whereas after a doubling of the variance of talent growth the tail takes 23.2 years to close half its gap, in an illustrative economy. Because a founder's wealth is proportional to her talent times a power of her fund's size, the tail's Pareto exponent is a closed-form, decreasing function of how accurately the market ranks founders when pairing them with funds. Venture-deal estimates put that accuracy around 1989 between 0.275 and 0.354, on a scale from random matching (zero) to perfect sorting (one); since only closed deals are observed, it may lie outside that range. With sorting in 1989 tied to these data, a ramp in sorting from 1980 carries the rise of the top 0.1% wealth share to 2001 and 2016 but only part of its early rise to 1989.

The 2025 QSBS Expansion and Startup Venture Rounds: A Double Machine Learning Event-Study Design
I study the 2025 increase in the QSBS gross-assets cap from $50M to $75M. Linking 126,000 startup venture rounds from the Fundraising Fox Open Dataset (Hugging Face) to 631,000 SEC Form D filings, I compare newly eligible with never-eligible startups of similar size using a double machine learning difference-in-differences and event-study design. Because the tax benefit accrues to angels, founders, employees and the partners of venture funds while a round aggregates all of its investors, the estimate is the startup-level net financing response. Investor breadth and the response of always-eligible small startups serve as evidence on mechanisms.

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Washington University in St. Louis

Spring 2025	Econ 4850: Economic Analysis with Python (undergraduate; designed course)
Spring 2025	Econ 6850: A First Python Course for Economists (master's; designed course)

Teaching Assistant, Washington University in St. Louis

Fall 2026	Econ 8135: Advanced Microeconometrics (Ph.D.)
Spring, Fall 2024	Econ 5141: Advanced Microeconometrics (Ph.D.)
Spring 2024	Econ 5175: Structural Microeconometrics (Ph.D.)
Spring 2023	Econ 502: Macroeconomics II (Ph.D.)
Fall 2022	Econ 501: Macroeconomics I (Ph.D.)

Teaching Assistant, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

2019–2021	Econ 2021: Basic Macroeconomics (twice); Econ 3430: Public Finance; Econ 3160: Game Theory

Research Experience

Summer 2023	Research Assistant to George-Levi Gayle and Limor Golan, Washington University in St. Louis

Presentation

2026	Institute of Economics, Academia Sinica (Macro Seminar)

Awards and Scholarships

2018–2019	Excellent Performance Award (best GPA), M.Sc. in Economics, CUHK
2018–2019	Admission Scholarship, M.Sc. in Economics, CUHK
2018–2019	Dean's List, Faculty of Social Science, CUHK (M.Sc.)
2015–2016	Dean's List, Faculty of Social Science, CUHK (B.S.Sc.)
2015–2016	Head's List, New Asia College, CUHK
2012–2013	Excellent Undergraduate Paper Award (Junior Division), Department of Economics, CUHK

Professional Activities

Referee	*Journal of Macroeconomics*
2023	Selected participant, Princeton Initiative: Macro, Money, and Finance

Skills and Languages

Programming	Python (primary), Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, Git
Languages	English (fluent), Cantonese (native), Mandarin (fluent)